

TEMPLATE REPO

AI Design Harness

Write design decisions down once, so people and AI agents build from the same place.

github.com/sadakoa/ai-design-harness

WHY

Why it exists

Design rules usually live in people's heads. The harness writes them down as small files, with three skills and one check, so an AI agent can follow them.

Today

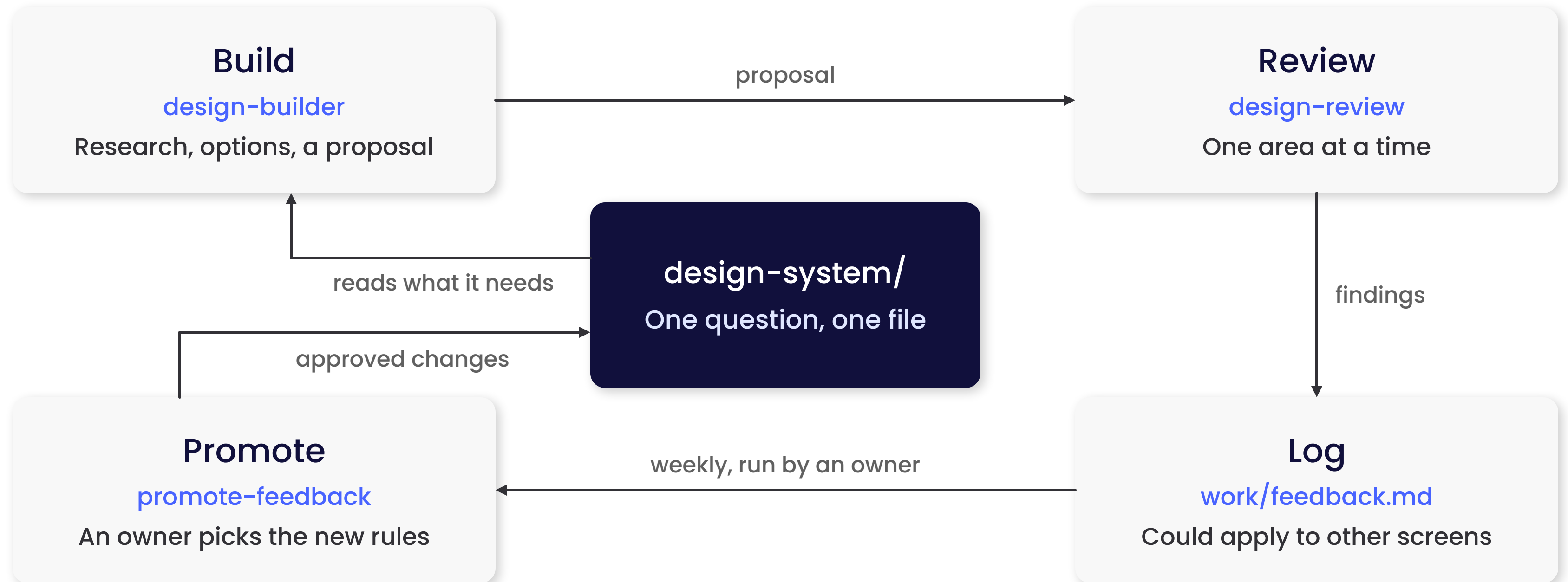
- ✗ One long doc mixes rules, values and one-off decisions
- ✗ Review comments are opinions with nothing to point to
- ✗ What a review teaches is lost in old threads

With the harness

- ✓ One question, one file
- ✓ Every review finding points to a named rule
- ✓ Findings flow back and become rules

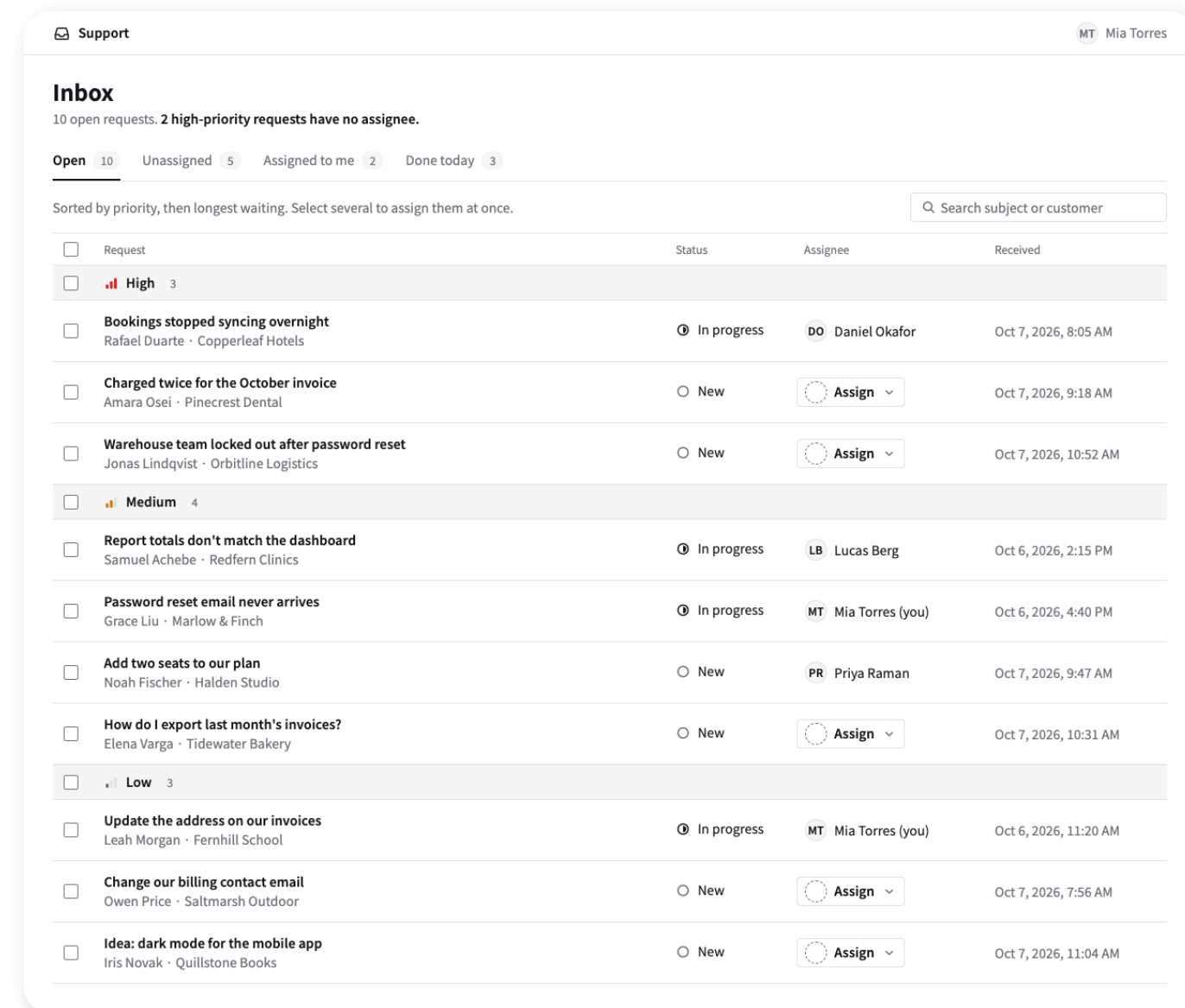
HOW IT FLOWS

The loop



WHAT YOU GET

One proposal per screen



One of three mockups in [examples/support-inbox](#)

In every proposal

- Research notes and assumptions
- About three working mockups
- A recommendation, with reasons
- A spec: structure, states, copy
- A review against your rules

It's an HTML page you open in a browser. It doesn't write production code — it gets you to a reviewed design.

IDEA 1

One question, one file

INDEX.md — the map: which file answers what, and what to read for each task

What is this value?
tokens/tokens.json

Which CSS variables can I use?
tokens/tokens.css (generated)

What do we choose, and why?
foundations/principles.md

What must we never do?
foundations/rules.md

How do we write UI text?
foundations/writing.md

Which component should I use?
components/GUIDE.md

How does this component behave?
components/<name>.md

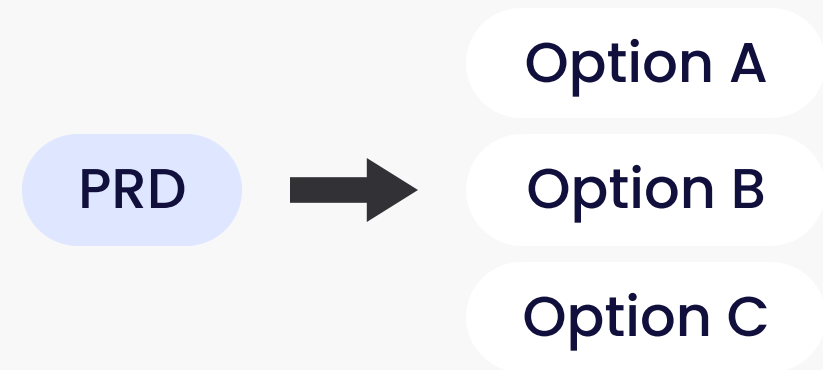
How do components make a screen?
patterns/GUIDE.md

What do approved screens look like?
screens/

Why did we decide this?
decisions.md

Build wide, review narrow

Build: open up

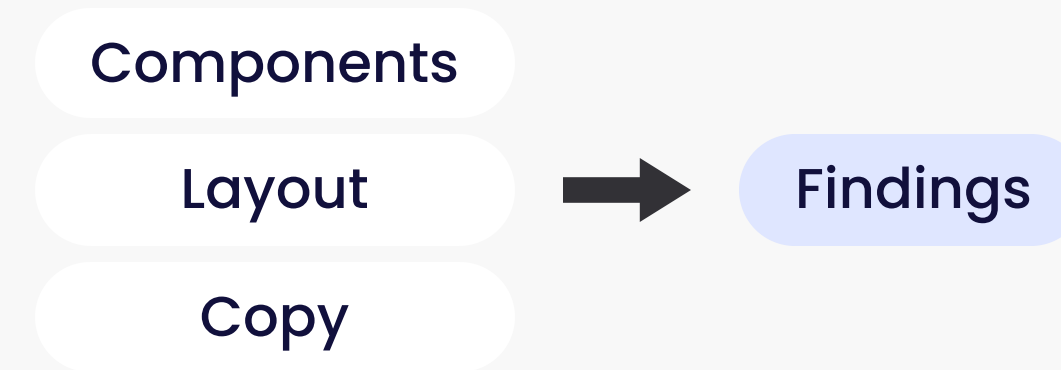


READS

principles · rules · writing
patterns · tokens.css · screens

When needed: components

Review: narrow down



READS, ONE AREA AT A TIME

Components: principles, rules, components, tokens

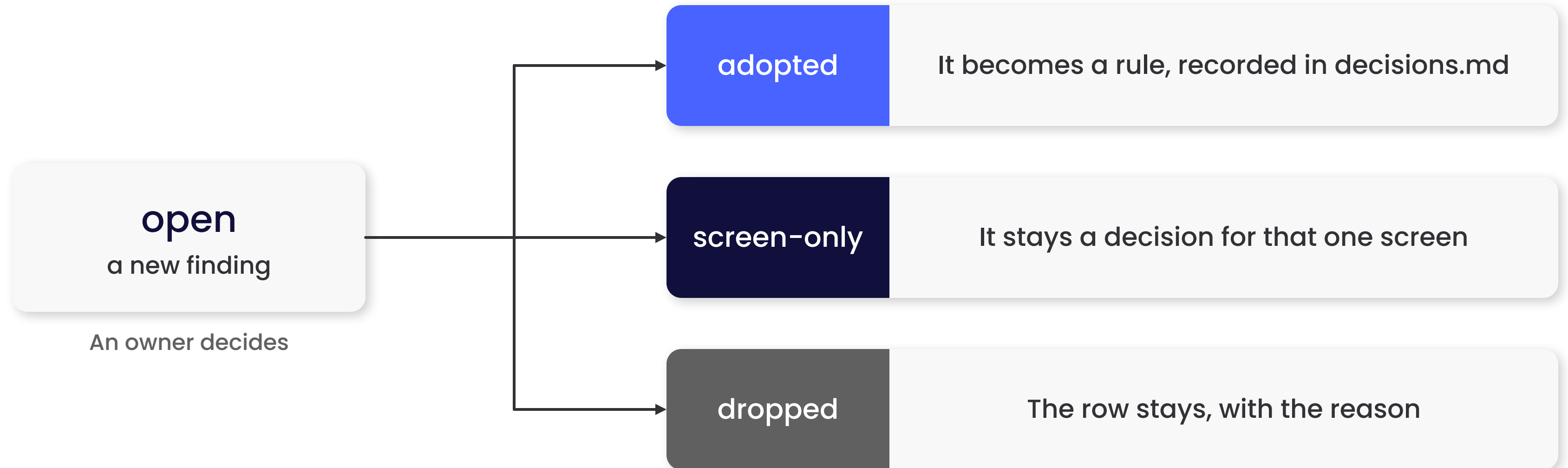
Layout: principles, rules, patterns

Copy: rules, writing

IDEA 3

Feed reviews back

Promote a finding when it came up on two or more screens, or the same rule was broken twice — and one file clearly owns it.



IN PRACTICE

design-builder, step by step

01

Read

Save the PRD in a new
feature folder

02

Frame

Whose task gets better,
and how

03

Ask you

Only what changes the
design (max 5)

04

Research

Approved screens first,
then others

05

Explore

About three working
options

06

Recommend

Pick one, tie it to a
principle

07

Write up

Everything on one HTML
page

08

Review

Run design-review, then
hand over

Running it as a team

Owners are the people listed in CODEOWNERS. They approve every change to the design system.

First months	Then	Every week	Approvals
Only owners change the design system. Decide in batches.	Designers open PRs too. Start with copy and guidelines.	An owner runs promote-feedback and decides.	With two or more owners, require their approval on GitHub.
NOT FOR	Brand-new kinds of screens. The agent drafts options; a designer should finish them.		

START

Your first hour

- 1 Use the repo as a template, or copy it into your product repo
- 2 Fill in the minimum: who it's for, your quality bar, your colors
- 3 Write a short PRD for one screen
- 4 Run `/design-builder` with it and answer its questions
- 5 Open `proposal.html` in a browser

What's inside	
<code>design-system/</code>	Your rules, one file each
<code>work/features/</code>	Proposals and reviews
<code>work/feedback.md</code>	The feedback log
<code>.claude/skills/</code>	The three skills
<code>scripts/</code>	The check

APPENDIX

Reading by task

• always · ○ when it's relevant · blank means skip · taken from INDEX.md

File	Build	Components	Layout	Copy	Promote
INDEX.md	•	•	•	•	•
tokens/tokens.css	•	•	○		
tokens/tokens.json					○
foundations/principles.md	•	•	•	○	•
foundations/rules.md	•	•	•	•	•
foundations/writing.md	•			•	○
components/GUIDE.md	○	•			○
components/<name>.md	○	○			○
patterns/GUIDE.md	•		•		○
screens/README.md	•		○		
decisions.md					•

What the check catches

`npm run check` runs on your machine and on every pull request.

File missing from INDEX

A file not listed in INDEX.md, or a different question

tokens.css out of date

tokens.json changed but tokens.css wasn't rebuilt

Hard-coded colors

Raw colors in screens and options (R-01)

Unknown variables

CSS variables that aren't in tokens.css

Duplicate IDs

Two entries share an ID: P- principle, R- rule, D- decision, FB- feedback

Adopted without a decision

Feedback marked adopted with no row in decisions.md